SECTION 2 · STORY 1

Seventy Thousand Seeds

Henry Wickham · the Amazon to Kew Gardens, London · 1876

In 1876, Henry Wickham, an Englishman living in the Amazon, shipped about 70,000 rubber seeds to Kew Gardens in London, paid by Britain's India Office. By his own later account, he told customs they were "exceedingly delicate botanical specimens". Brazil was then the world's main source of rubber. The seedlings went on to British Asia. For twenty years little changed; then plantation labour, investment and the demand for bicycle and car tyres turned them into an industry. By 1913 Asian plantations had overtaken the Amazon, and Brazil's rubber boom ended. Kerala's rubber trees descend largely from the same seeds.

In Brazil, Wickham is remembered as "the father of bio-piracy": someone who profited from Brazil's plants without its consent. Wickham called it patriotism. No Brazilian law in 1876 banned taking the seeds, Brazil kept its trees, and the plantations took decades of work to succeed. Britain knighted him in 1920.

Brazil kept its rubber trees.
What, if anything, did Britain take?